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Mr Burlingame
Cabinet



No 259 — 3 Enclosures

Legation of the United States
Peking, May 22c, 1873

Frederick F. Low

to

Department of State



Subject

Military preparations of the Chinese in the neighborhood of Tientsin.

Encloses copy of a dispatch from Mr Consul Sheppard on the subject; also correspondence between the Minister and Rear Admiral Jenkins.

No 259 3 Enclosures

Legation of the United States
Peking, May 22d, 1873.

Sir:-

Referring to my No 253 of 2d instant, I have now the honor to enclose copy of a despatch from Mr Consul Sheppard upon the same subject:- military operations in the vicinity of Tientsin. The statements of the Consul concerning the works now in course of construction, and his estimate of the number

of

Hon Hamilton Fish
Secretary of State

of native troops in that vicinity, are corroborated by other information which has come to me, and may be accepted as substantially correct.

As to the real object of these military preparations opinions differ. It is quite impossible to obtain reliable information concerning the purposes of the Chinese Government; hence opinions upon this subject must of necessity be to a large extent mere conjectures.

It is perhaps but natural that this Government should take steps to fortify

this

the main water approach to its capital, although the practicable usefulness of such works was demonstrated in in 1860, and would be again should occasion arise for moving a foreign army on Pekin; nor is it surprising that the Viceroy of this province — by far the ablest military mandarin in the Empire — should desire to have a large military force about him. The Empire being now exceptionally free from domestic disturbance few troops are required for active duty, hence there is no reason why an unusually

unusually large force may not be stationed in the vicinity of the Capital. So far as I am aware the total of the force in this province is not exceptionally large, and therefore there is nothing in this that can occasion alarm. It is the sudden concentration of troops near Tientsin that excites remark and causes uneasiness among foreigners.

The discussion of the Audience Question is regarded by most people as the principal cause of the recent military activity. It is not impossible that the

the Chinese at one time feared that trouble would grow out of this question; or it may be (which is much more likely) the officials thought that the assembling of troops near here would have an influence upon the foreign Ministers and cause them to moderate their demands. I is proper that I should, in this connection, observe that nothing has occurred in our discussions which leads me to think that such was the case; on the contrary the Chinese Ministers have never used language that could be construed into a threat, nor have

have they at any time intimated that the demand would possibly be resisted by force.

In a previous despatch I gave it as my opinion that the advent of a Japanese Embassy in China, which rumor said had come to make unpleasant demands upon this Government, was the chief cause of the warlike demonstrations before referred to; I also said that it was not probable the Chinese would inaugurate an offensive movement against Japan or any other nations. I am of the same opinion now

word.)

But while it is not likely that the safety of the lives or property of foreign residents will be materially affected by the presence of a greater or less number of native troops near Tientsin, I have deemed it prudent to take steps to allay to some extent the fears of our people residents in this vicinity, and also to afford them protection in case it shall be found necessary.

From my correspondence with Admiral Jenkins, copies of

2 of which are enclosed, you will learn what has been done in this direction, and also what I deem necessary in the immediate future.

It gives me pleasure to add that I have invariably found the Naval authorities ready and willing to cooperate in all measures necessary for the safety and well being of foreign residents.

I have the honor to be

Sir,

Your obedient servant

Frederick F. Low

Enclosures

No 1 Mr Sheppard to Mr Low
May 19, 1873.

No 2 Mr Low to Admiral Jenkins
May 13. 1873.

No 3 Admiral Jenkins to Mr Low
April 18, 1873.

Enclosure No 1
Despatch No 259

No. 12.

U. S. Consulate
Tientsin, May 19. 1873

Hon. S. S. Low
U. S. Minister, Peking.

Sir:—

I beg to lay before you for your information a few facts which I have gathered regarding certain military preparations on the part of the Chinese Government, within this immediate Consular district, during the past few days.

The first intimation I received of the presence of an unusual number of Chinese troops was about the 15th of April while passing down the river on my way to Chefoo. At that time a small body of soldiers were encamped in tents along and near the South bank of the Peiho near the village of Hsien Chêng — about eight miles West of the Taku forts and about

four

four miles east of the more important village of Ko Ku.

On my return a few days later, I discovered that this small force had been greatly augmented, and that the soldiers were busily engaged in throwing up strong earthworks and constructing forts in different places admirably suited to command the river in either direction. It was also ascertained that these troops had been moved down the Taku military road and past the Foreign Settlement of Tientsin at night, and that their force already consisted of about 15.000 troops mostly armed with Foreign rifles.

From the best information in my possession these troops came from a large camp at Ma Chang on the Grand Canal about 100 li south of Tientsin. A missionary who passed through that camp recently states that

these

there are about 60,000 soldiers there, all southern soldiers. A great portion of this body of soldiers is Cavalry.

I learn from reliable gentlemen who lately visited the south fort at Sabine that great activity is manifest at that garrison. The last of the three Cavaliers is being rapidly pushed forward to completion and will be finished in about two weeks. The other two Cavaliers were completed and three 100-pound Krupp guns mounted in each, commanding the entire entrance to the river. The rear defence of the Fort has been strengthened by a second and inner wall as high as the outer wall and about 20 feet from it. It has since transpired that guns are being mounted on this inner wall to the rear, and commanding the river in that direction also. A recent order

of

of the military Commandant was posted up in the fort ordering the soldiers not to neglect the work they were about, but to attend to their duties and not absent themselves, as the work then going forward was of the utmost importance.

On the Taku road five miles west of the Fort, a new entrenched camp of 300 men was found close to the road. This camp, like many of the others which are being established cannot be seen from the river, being hidden by clumps of trees. Three miles further west, the main encampment was found at Hsin Chêng. Hsin Chêng appears to be the name of a walled town that existed at this place some 60 or 70 years ago, of which nothing now remains but a few mounds.

The camps here extend for about a mile in double parallel lines on both sides of the Taku road. Seventeen camps were counted, but

but the number has since been increased to twenty eight. Two forts have already been built commanding the river. These forts, it is said, are to be mounted with guns cast at the Tientsin Arsenal.

The people and soldiers all say there are at present 20,000 soldiers in these camps, and that there are more to come, chiefly cavalry and Field Artillery. The soldiers are chiefly Honan men, and are, it is said, mostly armed with breech loading rifles. General Chow is in command.

As to the real object and purpose of this unusual and apparently unnecessary preparation on the part of the Chinese Government, it does not probably become me to venture a decided opinion at this time. The fact is, however, apparent that the Chinese are for some reason strengthening their military defences from

Taku

Taku to Tientsin. As these preparations are all being pushed forward with unmounted vigor and haste in a time of profound peace and without any apparent cause, it seems to me that such a proceeding, unexplained on the part of the Chinese Government, pending the discussion of a great international question so full of possible consequences as that of the Audience question now under consideration at Peking, is susceptible, at least of a very serious interpretation. Between civilized countries such an act would unquestionably be considered as a menace unless accompanied by satisfactory explanations.

I am, Sir,
Your obedient servant
(Signed) Eli S. Shepard
U.S. Consul

Enclosure No 2
Dispatch No 259

Legation of the United States.
Peking, May 13. 1873

Admiral:—

I have the honor to transmit copy of a note which I have addressed to Commander Bunce of the "Ashuelot."

In further explanation of the reasons for wishing to detain the "Ashuelot" at Tientsin, I would observe that within the last four weeks a large number of Chinese troops have been concentrated near the river between Tientsin and Taku, where entrenchments are being thrown up. it is also said that a new fortification is being built near the place where these soldiers are concentrated.

From information which may be considered reliable, I estimate the number of troops

I have &c
Thornton A. Jenkins
Com^dr in Chief Asiatic Fleet.

now

now encamped along the river between Tientsin and Taku at 15,000 to 20,000. There are also at other camps away from the river, but within ten or fifteen miles of Tientsin as many more, probably.

What these warlike demonstrations mean, I am unable to say. It is not impossible the Government thinks that this demonstration of force will have the effect to intimidate the Foreign Ministers who have made a request for personal Audience of the Emperor, or it may be a preparation for possible contingencies in case the demand is refused and foreign Governments decline to submit quietly to the rejection of their demand. My own impression is, however, that the reason for assembling these troops at this moment, may be set down to a desire on the part of the Chinese

to

to make something of a display of force as an intimation to the Japanese Embassy now here that unreasonable demands will be resisted. I do not anticipate in any event an offensive movement either against the Japanese or foreigners generally.

But while this is my belief I cannot shut my eyes to the possible danger there may be in these movements, nor to the necessity of adopting every reasonable precaution for the protection of the lives and property of our citizens in this vicinity.

In view of these considerations, I should regret to see the naval force now at Tientsin withdrawn.

I may add that Comdr Bunce's apparent anxiety to leave Tientsin is because his vessel needs repairs. But

even

even if repairs are necessary to render her safe and serviceable at sea, they would not, I imagine add to her usefulness in her present position.

If however it should be decided to withdraw the "Ashuelot" from Tientsin, I would most respectfully suggest that the Monocacy be sent to relieve her and that the former should remain, until relieved by the latter.

I have the honor to be,
Admiral,
Your obedient Servant
(Signed) Frederick F. Low

P.S. Since writing the foregoing I have received your despatch of 18. April. With reference to your suggestion about the "Gantic", I have to say that, if her presence is not absolutely needed elsewhere, I would be glad if she were ordered to Chefoo.

Enclosure No 3
Dispatch No 259

U. S. Ship "Hartford"
Flag Ship on the Asiatic Station
Hong Kong, April 18. 1873.

Sir:—

I have had the honor to receive to day your despatch dated April 5th informing me of your request to Commander Bunce, commanding the "Ashuelot," to delay his departure from Tientsin until the 1st of May or longer, should events seem to require the retention of the vessel at her present station.

I had already received despatches from Commander Bunce informing me of your request, and of his compliance therewith, and on the 7th instant transmitted to him instructions to remain at Tientsin until he is informed by you that the presence there of the ship is no longer necessary or until he is relieved

by

by another vessel.

I trust that it may not be necessary to keep the "Ashuelot" at Tientsin much longer, as her crew need a change, and the ship requires some repairs, but if it should seem to be important to have a vessel there I shall relieve her by another.

If you deem it to be of any advantage, either as a precaution or otherwise, I will order the "Yantic", a small sloop of war drawing about 13 feet of water, (just arrived on the Station) to Chefoo. As she could probably pass the Taku bar with a high tide, she might be useful, should difficulties arise.

I hope however that the present causes of uneasiness will soon be removed by a satisfactory settlement of the questions which have recently proved so embarrassing to the Ministers at Peking, and, meantime I beg to assure you that every suggestion from

from Yourself as to any measures which may lie in my power to carry into effect to assist you, will receive the most cordial and careful attention.

I expect to reach Shanghai on or before the 11th of May, and I shall be glad to receive there any communication you may favor me with.

I have the honor to be,
My dear Sir,
Your very obed.t servant.
(Signed) Thornton A. Jenkins
Rear Admiral
Comd.g U. S. Naval Force
on Asiatic Station

Hon. F. F. Low
United States Minister
&c &c &c
Peking, China.